

Application Sections

Project title

- Discovering hidden community leaders

Expected start date

between 1st Jan 2026 - 1st April 2026

1st February 2026

Expected end date

Start + 12 max months

31st July 2026

Summary (200 words)

In plain English, provide a summary of your proposal that we can publish on our website if funded. Do not include any confidential or sensitive information

Make it suitable for a variety of readers, for example:

- *Opinion-formers*
- *Policymakers*
- *the public*
- *the wider research community*

Clearly describe your proposed work in terms of:

- *Context*
- *the challenge(s) related to digital research technical professional leadership skills and careers that you will address*
- *aims and objectives*
- *potential impact and benefits*

Across the UK's Research Technical Professional (RTP) landscape, many individuals informally undertake Research Community Management (RCM) activities—such as coordinating open source contributions and sustaining communities of practice—without formal recognition, support, or inclusion in job descriptions. This lack of visibility and institutional backing creates a fragile and uneven foundation for community leadership, limiting incentives and career development opportunities for those performing this vital work.

This project seeks to build a deeper understanding of the scope, value, and impact of RCM within the research ecosystem. Through qualitative interviews with RTPs engaged in RCM activities, we will identify key competencies and explore how the absence of formalisation affects leadership and progression. Findings will extend the DIRECT Framework, particularly its Community and Outreach competencies, and inform the design of a statistically robust, construct-validated survey targeting the wider UK RTP community.

We will also map existing stakeholders and communities to identify engagement opportunities and support the emerging RCM community. Leveraging partnerships with the Software Sustainability Institute and Society of Research Software Engineering, all outputs will follow open research principles, ensuring FAIR and openly licensed materials. Ultimately, this work aims to support the professionalisation and recognition of RCM as a distinct and essential RTP role.

Team information

Please give details of all individuals who will lead this project.

- 1. Applicants must be led by digital Research Technical Professionals, and we are interested with which profession you most closely identify.*
- 2. Each co-lead will receive an email after submission asking them to provide optional EDI data. This will not be used in assessing proposals and will not be seen by reviewers. It will purely be used for analysis of submission patterns and funding outcomes by DisCouRSE and our independent advisory board as a guard against bias.*

Contributor #1 (Lyndsey)

- Name: Lyndsey Ballantyne
- Role:
 - ☒ Lead
 - ☐ Co-lead
- Email address: l.ballantyne@soton.ac.uk
- Organisation: Software Sustainability Institute - University of Southampton
- Organisation type:
 - ☒ UK higher education
 - ☐ UK eligible research organisation
 - ☐ UK business
 - ☐ UK third sector
 - ☐ UK government
 - ☐ Non-UK research organisation
 - ☐ Non-UK business
 - ☐ Non-UK third sector
- Division or department (optional):
- Profession (select only one)
 - ☐ Bioinformatician

- ☐ Community manager
- ☐ Data engineer
- ☐ Data Manager
- ☐ Data scientist, analyst, AI or machine learning specialist
- ☐ Data steward
- ☐ DevOps engineer
- ☐ Digital humanities technologist
- ☐ Digital librarian or Archivist
- ☐ HPC or Research Computing specialist
- ☐ Infrastructure specialist
- ☐ MLOps engineer
- ☐ PRISM (Professional Research Investment and Strategy Manager)
- ☐ Project Manager or Coordinator in a technical research context
- ☐ Research infrastructure engineer
- ☐ Research software engineer
- ☐ Software maintainer or open source contributor
- ☐ System administrator
- ☐ Technical research support Officer
- ☐ Other (please state below) Senior Enterprise Fellow
- Academic discipline(s) i.e. the disciplines that you primarily work with:
 - ☐ Arts and Humanities
 - ☒ Computer Science
 - ☐ Engineering and Technology
 - ☐ Life Sciences
 - ☐ Mathematical Science
 - ☐ Physical Sciences
 - ☐ Social Sciences
 - ☐ Other
 - ☐ None of the above
- %FTE to be worked on the project: 10%

Contributor #2 (Cass)

- Name: Cassandra Gould van Praag
- Role
 - ☐ Lead
 - ☒ Co-lead
- Email address: Cassandra.gouldvanpraag@rcmcooperative.com
- Organisation: RCM Cooperative
- Organisation type
 - ☐ UK higher education
 - ☐ UK eligible research organisation
 - ☒ UK business
 - ☐ UK third sector

- ☐ UK government
- ☐ Non-UK research organisation
- ☐ Non-UK business
- ☐ Non-UK third sector
- Division or department (optional):
- Profession (select only one)
 - ☐ Bioinformatician
 - ☒ Community manager
 - ☐ Data engineer
 - ☐ Data Manager
 - ☐ Data scientist, analyst, AI or machine learning specialist
 - ☐ Data steward
 - ☐ DevOps engineer
 - ☐ Digital humanities technologist
 - ☐ Digital librarian or Archivist
 - ☐ HPC or Research Computing specialist
 - ☐ Infrastructure specialist
 - ☐ MLOps engineer
 - ☐ PRISM (Professional Research Investment and Strategy Manager)
 - ☐ Project Manager or Coordinator in a technical research context
 - ☐ Research infrastructure engineer
 - ☐ Research software engineer
 - ☐ Software maintainer or open source contributor
 - ☐ System administrator
 - ☐ Technical research support Officer
 - ☐ Other (please state below)
- Academic discipline(s) i.e. the disciplines that you primarily work with:
 - ☐ Arts and Humanities
 - ☐ Computer Science
 - ☐ Engineering and Technology
 - ☒ Life Sciences
 - ☐ Mathematical Science
 - ☐ Physical Sciences
 - ☐ Social Sciences
 - ☐ Other
 - ☐ None of the above
- %FTE to be worked on the project: 25%

Contributor #3 (Emma)

- Name: Emma Karoune
- Role:
 - ☐ Lead
 - ☒ Co-lead

- Email address: ekaroune@googlemail.com
- Organisation: RCM Cooperative
- Organisation type:
 - ☐ UK higher education
 - ☐ UK eligible research organisation
 - ☒ UK business
 - ☐ UK third sector
 - ☐ UK government
 - ☐ Non-UK research organisation
 - ☐ Non-UK business
 - ☐ Non-UK third sector
- Division or department (optional):
- Profession (select only one)
 - ☐ Bioinformatician
 - ☒ Community manager
 - ☐ Data engineer
 - ☐ Data Manager
 - ☐ Data scientist, analyst, AI or machine learning specialist
 - ☐ Data steward
 - ☐ DevOps engineer
 - ☐ Digital humanities technologist
 - ☐ Digital librarian or Archivist
 - ☐ HPC or Research Computing specialist
 - ☐ Infrastructure specialist
 - ☐ MLOps engineer
 - ☐ PRISM (Professional Research Investment and Strategy Manager)
 - ☐ Project Manager or Coordinator in a technical research context
 - ☐ Research infrastructure engineer
 - ☐ Research software engineer
 - ☐ Software maintainer or open source contributor
 - ☐ System administrator
 - ☐ Technical research support Officer
 - ☐ Other (please state below)
- Academic discipline(s) i.e. the disciplines that you primarily work with:
 - ☐ Arts and Humanities
 - ☐ Computer Science
 - ☐ Engineering and Technology
 - ☐ Life Sciences
 - ☐ Mathematical Science
 - ☐ Physical Sciences
 - ☐ Social Sciences
 - ☒ Other - cross disciplinary
 - ☐ None of the above

- %FTE to be worked on the project: 25%

Contributor #4 (Oscar)

- Name: Oscar Seip
- Role:
 - ☐ Lead
 - ☒ Co-lead
- Email address: oscar.seip@manchester.ac.uk
- Organisation: Software Sustainability Institute - University of Manchester
- Organisation type:
 - ☒ UK higher education
 - ☐ UK eligible research organisation
 - ☐ UK business
 - ☐ UK third sector
 - ☐ UK government
 - ☐ Non-UK research organisation
 - ☐ Non-UK business
 - ☐ Non-UK third sector
- Division or department (optional): Computer Sciences (UoM)
- Profession (select only one)
 - ☐ Bioinformatician
 - ☒ Community manager
 - ☐ Data engineer
 - ☐ Data Manager
 - ☐ Data scientist, analyst, AI or machine learning specialist
 - ☐ Data steward
 - ☐ DevOps engineer
 - ☐ Digital humanities technologist
 - ☐ Digital librarian or Archivist
 - ☐ HPC or Research Computing specialist
 - ☐ Infrastructure specialist
 - ☐ MLOps engineer
 - ☐ PRISM (Professional Research Investment and Strategy Manager)
 - ☐ Project Manager or Coordinator in a technical research context
 - ☐ Research infrastructure engineer
 - ☐ Research software engineer
 - ☐ Software maintainer or open source contributor
 - ☐ System administrator
 - ☐ Technical research support Officer
 - ☐ Other (please state below)
- Academic discipline(s) i.e. the disciplines that you primarily work with:
 - ☒ Arts and Humanities
 - ☒ Computer Science

- ☒ Engineering and Technology
- ☒ Life Sciences
- ☒ Mathematical Science
- ☒ Physical Sciences
- ☒ Social Sciences
- ☐ Other
- ☐ None of the above
- %FTE to be worked on the project: 0.05 FTE to 31/05/2026, then 0% (in kind)

Vision (200 words)

Describe the overall aims of the project, setting out the problem you are trying to solve or the change you are seeking to achieve. List your intended outcomes. How do these align to the objectives of the call and the DisCouRSE network aims?

What the assessors are looking for in your response

We want to see that:

- *your proposal's aims are aligned to the priorities of the DisCouRSE network*
- *the expected outcomes of the project are clear and relevant*
- *the work is timely and needed, e.g. addressing an unmet need in the digital RTP community*
- *you have clearly identified the beneficiaries of your work and how they will benefit*

Across the UK's Research Technical Professional (RTP) landscape, many individuals informally take on Research Community Management (RCM) activities such as coordinating contributions to open source projects, and sustaining communities of practice. However, these contributions are often hidden since they fall outside formal job descriptions, with little to no professional recognition, time, or support. This creates a structural imbalance where essential community leadership is fragile, unsustainable and inconsistently supported across institutions. Consequently, there is limited incentive and opportunity for individuals to take on community leadership or roles that underpins the socio-technical infrastructure vital to collaboration and innovation.

This project aims to create a deeper understanding of the scope and value of RCM work within the research ecosystem. Through a series of qualitative interviews, we will examine the competencies of community builders, and how the lack of formalisation affects both leadership and career development. This will extend the DIRECT Framework and inform the design of a future survey among the wider UK RTP community. Ultimately, this project aims to provide evidence towards the better recognition and professionalisation of the distinct RTP role of RCMs, such that they are understood to be an essential component in the leadership of an effective research ecosystem.

Approach (200 words)

How will you achieve your aims? Include just enough detail to assess feasibility, with a timeline of activities / key milestones.

What the assessors are looking for in your response

Explain how you have designed your approach so that it:

- *is effective and appropriate to achieve your objectives*
- *is committed to openness and sharing with the community*
- *will maximise translation of outputs into outcomes and impacts*

To collect evidence that many RTPs informally take on RCM work, we are leveraging our connections with Software Sustainability Institute (SSI) and Society of RSE (SocRSE). Through qualitative interviews, we will explore the competencies and skills of those doing RCM activities and feed findings into the DIRECT Framework, specifically the Community and Outreach competencies. This work will inform the design of a statistically robust and construct-validated survey for the wider RTP population, providing insights into RCM skills and competencies, leadership and career development, and the importance of recognising RCM activities to support sustainable research communities.

We will also map existing organisations and communities to identify areas for engagement with the emerging RCM community. All activities will follow an open research approach with materials and outputs FAIR and openly licensed, ensuring broader benefit to the RTP community.

Schedule

Dates	Activities
Feb-March 2026	Project set up • Data protection ◦ DMP ◦ DPAP • Ethics approval ◦ Develop interview script ◦ Consent forms • Financial set up • Pre-registration of methodology Stakeholder mapping of RCM landscape to identify leads for qualitative interviews
Apr-May 2026	Qual interviews (n=20 max) Concurrent Thematic analysis Further stakeholder mapping

Jun-July 2026	Finish thematic analysis of interviews Report writing Publish report and stakeholder mapping openly
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Risks and Mitigations (200 words)

What are the major risks that might prevent achieving your intended outcomes, and how will you mitigate these? How will you assess whether the project has been a success, over the short, medium, and long term?

What the assessors are looking for in your response

Show that you:

- *are aware of how to assess whether your outcomes have been achieved*
- *have identified risks to this delivery and how they will be managed*

Risks	Mitigations
Slow project set up - data protection and ethics review	Team members are familiar with lead organisations processes and can expedite this work.
Lack of team capacity	- Large team to distribute responsibilities - Realistic, modular and extensible work plan appropriate for the current level of resourcing. - Collaborative and coordinated approach across all work packages for on-time delivery.
Lack of community engagement	- Comprehensive stakeholder mapping to target relevant audience - Multiple communication channels to increase awareness of project - Intentional targeting of our extensive networks - Open research approach for greater accessibility to project

Timescale	Success indicator
Short term: Deliverables	- Qualitative interviews analysed to inform a rigorous vocabulary for understanding RCM work. - Stakeholder map.
Short term: Best practice	Establishing the first funded UK integration of disparate RCM groups.

	• Integrating our individual best practices for collaboration. • Sharing of open and reproducible data-science informed frameworks for collaboration into The Turing Way. • Contribution of skills into DIRECT.
Medium term	• Submission of a high value grant to develop system interventions to support RCM professionalisation.
Long term	• Award of funding to support the establishment of RCMs as an essential research leadership role.

Responsible research and innovation (150 words)

What are the ethical or RRI implications of your work? How will you ensure that the future digital RTP leadership community is built in an equitable, diverse, and inclusive manner?

What the assessors are looking for in your response

Explain how you:

- *will build EDI considerations into your activities*
- *will seek to limit adverse environmental impacts*

Many RCM activities are informal and unrecognised, meaning that only people with funding, institutional support, or the privilege of time can undertake leadership responsibilities. This limits who can participate in and benefit from community leadership, and disadvantages those undertaking RCM work by restricting career progression. There is also an indication that there may be a gender imbalance to this workload, associated with “care” and “facilitatory” roles.

We will conduct stakeholder mapping to identify and select individuals to interview from a range of backgrounds to ensure diversity of perspective. Our open research approach ensures accessible knowledge exchange and multiple channels of communication will lower the barriers to engagement. Other measures include a full ethics review, completing the Data Protection Assessment process, a GDPR-compliant Data Management Plan and the delivery of FAIR outputs. Contributors will be fairly credited using the CRediT taxonomy, and environmental impact will be minimised through remote collaboration.

Team capability to deliver (200 words)

Why are you the right team to deliver the proposed work successfully? Use a narrative format to showcase the range of relevant skills you, and if relevant your team (co-leads, researchers, technicians, specialists, partners and so on) have and how this will help to deliver the proposed work. You can include individuals' specific achievements but only choose past contributions that best evidence their ability to deliver this work. Note that you do not need to use the Résumé for Research and Innovation (R4RI) module headings.

What the assessors are looking for in your response

Evidence of how you and your team have:

- *the relevant experience (appropriate to career stage) and organisational support to deliver the proposed work*
- *the right balance of skills and expertise to cover the proposed work*
- *the appropriate leadership and management skills to deliver the work*
- *contributed to developing a positive research environment and wider community*

Our team are all experienced community builders and research leaders having worked across multiple domains for the past 20 years.

All of the community managers on the team have extensive experience building and maintaining open research communities including The Turing Way, Open Life Science, Open Phytoliths, University of Oxford, the international RSE movement, the Software Sustainability Institute and UK TRE.

Lyndsey has led large teams responsible for delivering major public programmes, including international conferences and a national advocacy campaign, the Hidden REF. She brings valuable strategic insight from her experience managing the national RSE community.

She will be supported in shaping the community research by Emma, Oscar and Cass - who all have experience facilitating research in open research communities and translating that research into action. Emma and Cass co-founded the RCM Cooperative to launch a new RTP community and deliver training on RCM fundamentals.

Oscar and Cass have each contributed to research and policy initiatives with organisations like ADRUK, the Tenenbaum Open Science Institute and UKRI. Emma has experience leading qualitative research projects including [Professionalizing data science careers](#) and [Advancing biomedical data science careers](#), which both focus on documenting the current data science and RTP ecosystem.

Resource and cost justification (200 words)

What will you need to deliver your proposed work and how much will it cost?

What the assessors are looking for in your response

Justify the application's more costly resources, in particular:

- *project staff*
- *travel and subsistence estimates for events*

Assessors are not looking for detailed costs or a line-by-line breakdown of all project resources. Overall, they want to be assured that:

- *all resources are appropriate and justified*
- *the project will make optimal use of resources to achieve the intended outcomes*

See this sheet for RCM Coop budget: [📄 Budget-DisCouRSE-Flexible-Fund-20250924](#)
Headings request in the grant submission platform are in the tab
“summary-for-client”

Staff costs

Project Lead

Lyndsey will oversee the delivery of the project and offer strategic insight based on relevant experience and connections in the RSE and Hidden REF Communities.

Co-leads

Cass will lead the community research by completing data protection and ethics processes, developing the qualitative study design, conducting interviews and doing analysis and report writing.

Oscar and Emma will lead the stakeholder mapping. They will also contribute to the community research including conducting analysis and writing of the report.

They will all work collaboratively to link this work with the DIRECT Framework, and ensure best practice in open documentation of activities.

Organisational approval

- ☒ The project lead is eligible within their own organisation to be a recipient of the grant funding, and this has been approved by the individual's organisation's relevant internal sign off processes.
- ☒ ~~Proof of internal approval e.g. screenshot or email (file to be uploaded — link here)~~

Email address of a finance and research support contact for the application who will be able to action the award agreement if funded, and can confirm internal approval:

Name of the support contact above:

Equality, Diversity, Inclusion, and Accessibility

These refer to the overall project lead only. While they are required, you may answer 'prefer not to say' in each case. Information provided here will not be used in assessing proposals and will not be seen by reviewers. It will purely be used for analysis of submission patterns and funding outcomes by DisCouRSE and our independent advisory board as a guard against bias.

- Gender (tick box options)
- Ethnicity (tick box options)
- Career stage (tick box options)